King Chemo

By Brian Guehring

Suggested Roles: ***Actress*** *– Melissa, Ice Queen, PuppetMan (scene 1), Doctor & Nurse (Scene 3), Agent 5/Doctor (Scene 4), Doctor (Scene 5)*
Actor *- Kevin, Doctor & Nurse (Scene 2), Agent X/ Nurse (Scene 4), Nurse (Scene 5)*

NOTE: This cutting asks each student to portray multiple characters, which is permissible for Nationals and SOME states. It may not meet the rules requirement for DUO in your state! Be sure to check your STATE rules before performing at local tournaments.

(Superhero music fades up)

KEVIN: *(in a recorded voice-over).* Welcome back to "THE ADVENTURES OF INVINCIBLE BOY, Defender of Youth." When we last left our hero [a normal boy in appearance, but born of superhuman strength, agility, and intelligence], he had just been captured by his evil arch enemy, the Ice Queen *(The ICE QUEEN enters wearing an ice-blue villainess costume [slightly resembling pastel-blue hospital scrubs}.)* [the famous rising figure skating star who tragically crashed through thin ice transforming her into a villainess with an ice heart] and her devoted lackey, Puppet Man *(PUPPET MAN enters wearing a marionette outfit [also remarkably resembling hospital scrubs].)*

INTRODUCTION

ACTRESS: *When we were small children, trying to get to sleep, a creaking floorboard was really spooky.*
ACTOR: *There's a pirate coming up the stairs . . .*
ACTRESS: *. . . or a monster in the closet,*
ACTOR: *or more probably a dragon under the bed.*
ACTRESS: *Adults chuckle at the "pretend" world of children, but really, it's the "safe" place of pretend that prepares children to accept the world's harsh realities.*
ACTOR: *Facing reality head-on is scarier than pirates or burglars or crocodiles . . . especially when that reality is cancer and the treatments that go along with the disease.*
ACTRESS: *Kevin is a 10-year-old with an active imagination who has returned to the hospital for chemotherapy.*

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ACTOR: *His fantasies help him cope and allow him to believe, if only for a short time that leukemia doesn't actually exist but is rather a plot by the "Powers That Be.*
TOGETHER: *King Chemo by Brian Guehring*

******* SCENE 1*******

KEVIN*:* So, we meet again, Ice Queen.

ICE QUEEN: Yes, Invincible Boy, and this time there is no escape. Puppet Man, get our prisoner a glass of ice water. *(PUPPET MAN goes to get a glass of water.)* I want you to feel welcome in my ice castle. Is it cold enough for you?

KEVIN: You can't freeze me, Ice Witch.

ICE QUEEN: You should really give up that heroism thing. It's so passe. You should join our side.

KEVIN: Join you? To do what?

ICE QUEEN: To eliminate fun, imagination, and everything that brings happiness. To create a world where pain, seriousness, and logic dominate the world.

KEVIN: How do you plan to accomplish this?

ICE QUEEN: By stealing toys, freezing amusement parks, and making boring television. If all else fails . . . we'll kill all the happy people. I could use you, Invincible Boy. Your superhuman strength, agility, and intelligence would help us. What do you say, partners?

KEVIN: Never.

ICE QUEEN: Maybe we can change your mind. Puppet Man, give him "the pill."

KEVIN: I won't take it.

ICE QUEEN: I think you will. *(ICE QUEEN opens a drawer and dry ice smoke falls out as she selects a torture device [resembling a stethoscope}. ICE QUEEN places the torture device on KEVIN's back.)*

KEVIN: AAAAHHHHH!

ICE QUEEN: So sorry, was that cold for you?

PUPPET MAN: This should answer any more questions you have about the plan of attack. *(PUPPET MAN hands him a pamphlet.)*

KEVIN: *(reading).* "Cold-bloodedness and You: How an Emotionless Existence Increases Longevity." I'll never join you.

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ICE QUEEN: Do you think you are strong enough to resist? Puppet Man, begin the ice treatment.

KEVIN: You can never defeat me. I am Invincible Boy, Defender of Youth!

ICE QUEEN: You won't be for much longer. *(PUPPET MAN attaches a torture device [somewhat resembling an IV] on KEVIN's arm. KEVIN braces himself for the pain.)* This treatment will slowly replace your blood cells with ice crystals. Later we'll replace your bones with icicles and your spinal fluid with ice water. You have four days to either join our side or permanently become Icicle Boy.

KEVIN: I'm strong enough to resist you.

ICE QUEEN: We'll see. For now, sit back and chill, Invincible Boy. We'll be back soon to start with your bones and spinal fluid.

******* SCENE 2*******

(The fantasy music fades. Lights reveal a small hospital room. MELISSA is sitting in her room as NURSE and DOCTOR enter.)

MELISSA: Good morning.

DOCTOR: Good morning, Melissa. Would you like a glass of ice water?

MELISSA: Yes, please. *(NURSE goes to get a glass of water.)*

DOCTOR: Melissa, we want you to be as comfortable as possible here. Is the room temperature OK?

MELISSA: It's fine. *(NURSE hands MELISSA drink.)* Thank you.

DOCTOR: We are about to start the treatment, but remember I can't do this alone. I need your help.

MELISSA & DOCTOR: Partners.

NURSE: This is to help you so you won't get nauseated. *(Handing MELISSA a pill.)*

DOCTOR: Now I'm just going to check your breathing. I'm sorry but this might be cold. *(DOCTOR uses stethoscope to check MELISSA's breathing.)*

NURSE: We brought you another pamphlet. *(NURSE hands MELISSA a pamphlet.)*

MELISSA: "Chemotherapy and You: How a Nutritious Diet Aids Treatment." Thanks . . . So

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what's going to happen today?

NURSE: You're scheduled for [chemotherapy at] 2:00 this afternoon. We're going to begin your IV now. *(NURSE begins hooking up her IV to her infusaport)* I'll get Kevin so we can start his tests. *(NURSE and DOCTOR exit. MELISSA starts to read pamphlet. KEVIN sneaks into the room and sees MELISSA.)*

******* SCENE 3*******

KEVIN: Hey! Don't read that! *(KEVIN rushes and takes the pamphlet away from her and starts jumping up and down on the pamphlet.)* Don't believe a word in this.

MELISSA: What are you doing?

KEVIN: I'm destroying the evil propaganda from the Ice Queen. She gives it to everyone. *(KEVIN shows MELISSA his pamphlet then rips up the pamphlets.)*

MELISSA: You're ripping up pamphlets on nutrition.

KEVIN: You can thank me later. So what brings you here?

MELISSA: Considering this is the cancer floor of a hospital, it's probably a safe bet I have cancer.

KEVIN: You must be a rookie. You see, I've been doing this for over a year now. I'm the king of chemotherapy. If you have any questions, just ask me. I've helped a lot of young kids get through chemotherapy. I fill them in on what's really going on. For instance ... *(KEVIN goes to the hall to check for signs of the DOCTOR.)* You have to watch out for the "doctor."

MELISSA: Why? She's been very nice to me.

KEVIN: Acting nice to you, but in reality she is pure ... Evil. She won't be able to hide it for much longer if you watch closely.

MELISSA: She's mean to all leukemia patients?

KEVIN: Yes. You see, only the really special kids get leukemia. The few, the proud, the leukemia kids. It's actually a great honor to be chosen for chemo.

MELISSA: Chemotherapy is an honor?

KEVIN: No. Chemo is terrible. The honor is being chosen. It means you were too strong to be broken through the usual means.

MELISSA: Who wants to break us?

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KEVIN: *(whispering)* The Powers That Be. See, there is someone out there trying to control us Earth children. Obviously the entire hospital staff is in on the plan. I'm not sure who's behind it yet, but I think it's the "doctor." My mission is to discover who they really are and save the world's children from their evil plots.

MELISSA: How do the Powers that Be use leukemia?

KEVIN: They're trying chemicals. It won't work though. They can't control this mind.

MELISSA: Kevin, this may be a crazy idea, but have you ever considered the possibility that the chemotherapy is to stop the cancer?

KEVIN: Melissa, Melissa, Melissa. You are so young and naive. I can tell I have a lot to teach you about the real world. I'm not sick. They made this cancer thing up.

MELISSA: They didn't make cancer up.

KEVIN: They did. Ladies and gentlemen of the jury, I'm here to prove that leukemia doesn't exist. I would like to call an "alleged" leukemia patient to the stand. Miss Melissa, do you swear to tell the truth, the whole truth, and nothing but the truth so help you Elvis?

MELISSA: Sure.

KEVIN: Now, Miss Melissa, does your cancer hurt like a broken bone? [or] do you get a fever like you do when you get the flu?

MELISSA: No.

KEVIN: Ah-ha! Why are you still in the hospital, then? *(Before MELISSA can answer.)* Melissa, can they show you an X-ray and point out the leukemia?

MELISSA: Not an X-ray. But they have tests. They can extract a sample of bone marrow from your hip and determine if you have leukemia. They show you the test results.

KEVIN: Which are what? Photos? Numbers? Charts? Graphs?

MELISSA: They show you the number of cancer cells.

KEVIN: Numbers? Could they make up these numbers?

MELISSA: Well yeah, but. ..

KEVIN: *(cutting her off).* Ah-ha! Now, ma'am, is leukemia contagious? How did you get it?

MELISSA: They don't know yet how people get leukemia.

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KEVIN: Because it doesn't exist? Ladies and gentlemen, I rest my case. *(NURSE clears throat. KEVIN hits the floor to hide behind the bed, but his IV is still clearly visible.)*

NURSE: Hoarding all the IVs, Melissa? Kevin, you can come out now.

KEVIN: *(in a high-pitched voice).* He's not here.

NURSE: Kevin, your bone marrow test and spinal tap are scheduled for right now. *(DOCTOR enters taking off her gloves.)*

DOCTOR: You can't just avoid these procedures, Kevin. Not taking the tests won't change whether you are in remission or not. I know a transplant is a scary idea, but you have to take these tests.

KEVIN: You'll try and give me a transplant no matter what your little experiments say.

DOCTOR: No, if you're in remission, no transplant. Trust me. *(her pager goes off).* Kevin, I can't argue now. *(DOCTOR and NURSE exit.)*

KEVIN: *(to Melissa)* [See] the doctor wants to use me as a guinea pig for her evil experiments.

MELISSA: They aren't experiments. It's treatment to fight the cancer.

KEVIN: Then why are the "doctor" and nurse are always wearing gloves? It's very suspicious.

MELISSA: It's so they don't touch the blood.

KEVIN: Nah, they wear gloves so they won't leave any fingerprints. They don't want to leave any evidence of their experiments. I'll prove it to you. C'mon.. *(KEVIN and MELISSA exit.)*

******* SCENE 4*******

(The secret agent command post. KEVIN enters a smoky, dark room with file cabinets, large tracking maps, blinking countertops, and sophisticated computers. He gradually gets weaker and dizzier as the scene progresses. KEVIN picks the lock and walks in. Alarm goes off "IN-TRUDER DETECTED." Lasers shoot off and KEVIN ducks many in slow motion. He is slightly injured as he dives out of the way.)

KEVIN: Powers That Be Command Central. There has to be proof of their plot here somewhere. Let's try here first. *(KEVIN jimmies the lock on the files and begins looking for his file.)* Bingo. *(KEVIN hears footsteps and hides as AGENT X enters. He wears a dark trench coat, sunglasses and a large hat. AGENT X walks over to the files.)*

AGENT X: The alarm was triggered. Someone has been in here. *(AGENT X notices broken lock and searches for file.)* Double O 5 won't like this. *(A secret code knock is heard at the door.*

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AGENT X answers with a code knock.) The bald condor flies upside down.

AGENT 5: *(off).* My mother's hanky is snotty and stanky. *(AGENT X opens door and lets AGENT 5 enter. AGENT X checks the hall behind her. AGENT 5 is also wearing a dark trench coat and sunglasses.)*

AGENT X: I'm glad I caught you before you left. The target has flown the coop. I just went to his room and he's gone.

AGENT 5: Then track him! Signal his honing device and get him.

AGENT X: I can't. He took it out. It's still in his room.

AGENT 5: He's not plugged into the system? I told you we should have operated to implant it. Why would he take it out?

AGENT X: Maybe he discovered "the truth."

AGENT 5: Impossible. He's a kid. Nobody would believe him. Everyone ignores kids. What proof does he have?

AGENT X: Someone broke into the files and his file is missing. But as long as he can't get into the computer we're fine.

AGENT 5: We have to find him before the whole operation is blown. This is bad timing, we just got clearance for the "procedure."

AGENT X: If the "procedure" worked, we wouldn't have to worry about him again. Ever. *(AGENTS notice Kevin hiding behind a file cabinet and assume the personas of medical personnel)*

DOCTOR/5: Kevin! What are you doing here?

KEVIN: I know about the Powers That Be.

DOCTOR/5: Where is your IV, Kevin? You need those antibiotics.

KEVIN: I took your little signal out.

DOCTOR/5: You don't look good. I'm taking you back to your room now. *(slowly moves toward KEVIN).* This is not time for one of your games. Without your IV, you will be weak, and things will seem out of control.

KEVIN: *(escapes and runs to file cabinet, breathing hard).* What are you trying to do? You're

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trying to take our freedom away! How are you doing it? *(MELISSA enters from where she has been hiding)* Melissa, get out of here!

MELISSA: You don't have to protect me, Kevin. I'm a spy working to expose the conspiracy, too. See the badge? How can I help you?

KEVIN: This is the command center and this is a spy, code name 5. She's in charge of the government plot.

DOCTOR/5: Kevin, I'm a doctor and this is our medical file room.

KEVIN: Stop lying. Tell me what this Procedure really is.

DOCTOR/5: It's a bone marrow transplant. Melissa, tell him I'm not some evil secret agent.

MELISSA: Kevin knows the two of you are secret government agents. What he doesn't know is that you're on our side. That you two are also working to destroy the Powers That Be. Right?

NURSE/X: Exactly, we're all fighting the same enemy, Kevin.

MELISSA: Our enemy isn't human, Kevin.

NURSE/X: Right. It is a strange invisible creature of origins unknown.

DOCTOR/5: I've studied it. I know how it attacks and how to strengthen your defense. I'm not going to take away your weapons to fight the Powers That Be. I'm adding to them.

KEVIN: *(after a pause, collapses in exhaustion).* OK.

******* SCENE 5*******

(KEVIN's hospital room. KEVIN is in his bed as DOCTOR and NURSE finish checkup.)

DOCTOR: Everything looks good. Your force field is working well and you're still on track to get your new ammunition in a couple of weeks. Very powerful. It can destroy anything.

NURSE: With heat-seeking target-locking capabilities. *(NURSE exits with DOCTOR.)*

MELISSA: *(entering slowly)* Hey, stranger! How are you doing?

KEVIN: Look, I was so weak last week because of my blood count. It wasn't me; it was the blood. Anemia. Once I got a new IV bag, I was fine.

MELISSA: I understand. I feel powerless when I have no energy.

KEVIN: *(showing his infusaport).* Look, I got a port. I'm going to have a bone marrow

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transplant in a couple of weeks.

MELISSA: Do you think your energy will be back by next week? We should go on an adventure.

KEVIN: I don't know. Where do you want to go? To the exciting library? Or the cemetery?

MELISSA: No, it'll be fun, I promise. And no adventures about death. Listen, I didn't tell you this before because I had to make sure I could trust you. You see, I'm actually a superhero. I only recently discovered my superpowers. I have to fight all types of threats like mutant organisms, bizarre creatures, and monsters. I thought I might need a new sidekick.

KEVIN: Sidekick? Don't think so. I already am a superhero. How about equal partner?

MELISSA: Deal.

KEVIN: I'll try to recruit the doctors and nurses to join us. They can be our sidekicks. They have superpowers, too, just not as strong as ours.

MELISSA: Well, they are adults. *(pause)* I'll see you next week. *(MELISSA starts to leave.)* Oh, and Kevin, don't forget to wear your tights.

KEVIN: Tights?

MELISSA: You can't be a superhero without them . . . Boys.

SOURCE INFORMATION

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AWARD HISTORY

2008 National Qualifier
2009 National Qualifier
2011 National Qualifier
2012 National Qualifier
2013 National Qualifier
2014 National Qualifier
2021 National Qualifier
2023 National Qualifier
2024 National Qualifier
2024 National Qualifier - MS NIETOC
CA State Qualifier
CO State Qualifier
IN State Qualifier
KS State Qualifier
MN State Qualifier
OH State Qualifier

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